

set to Cloud Licensing (SM only)

4. Field: L&R: License troubleshooting

This field is kept hidden until step 3 is complete.

Select the most appropriate option to describe the problem the customer encountered:

- Customer issue
- Multiple unique subscriptions
- Multi-year license conflict (formerly named "Multi-year license")
- New license activation bug
- Transition legacy to cloud

SECTION: support/managers/_index.md

Role and Responsibilities

As a Support Manager at GitLab, you will be focusing on the following things:

- Meeting the Support KPIs
- Growing and managing your team's efforts in support of the Support KPIs
- Mentoring and coaching your team on our technologies and processes
- Collaborate with other managers across regions
- Enable our engineers to explore process change in a scalable way

You can read more about the role below:

- Support Manager Responsibilities
- Support Management Job Family

Regional Variations

Some teams have slight tactical differences, you can see distinctive of regional approaches on the following pages:

- AMER

How to see what the Support managers are working on

Epics

The Support Team uses Epics to track and coordinate ongoing projects. For the master epics, a Support manager will be assigned as a Directly Responsible Individual (DRI) you will see their name in parentheses after the Epic title.

Support Leadership Meetings

As a larger leadership team, it's important that we remain in constant communication to ensure that we're building relationships and avoiding siloing. You can read more about how we run our Leadership syncs in our handbook.

Senior Leadership Meetings

While managers won't generally directly participate in Senior Leadership Meetings, it's important to know they exist, what topics are discussed at what cadence and where the public agenda is. Read more about Senior Leadership Meetings.

Working with your team

1. Getting To Know Your Team Members

1. Support 1-1s - guidance on conducting 1 to 1 calls.

Hiring

See Support Hiring

Promotions

See Promoting a team member

Metrics

As a Support Management group we should be aware of the tooling we use to generate the metrics that we report on.

1. Sisense

1. Zendesk Explore

Sisense

Sisense is a general purpose visualization tool that is used by the greater company.

It's extremely powerful with a full SQL interface to our data across functions.

We work with the data team to generate "Stable" Graphs here. Think, KPIs and greater measures that make sense to report to the larger company.

As managers, we will not need to edit these reports often, but we should be consuming it regularly.

Zendesk Explore

Zendesk Explore was released to replace Zendesk Insights. We will use this tool for quick interactions on new ideas or fact checking Sisense data. Support Managers should be ready to work with Explore regularly and be comfortable with the tool.

Why two metrics systems?

Sisense is a company wide tool that is extremely powerful which can make it unwieldy. Explore gives us an interface that is much easier to navigate and use.

Additionally, Sisense data is a secondary source so it can contain errors. By being comfortable using ZD Explore, a primary source, we can make sure that we have accurate data and insights.

What happens if we are not hitting our KPIs?

Each week in the Support Leadership Meetings we'll review the key metrics.

If the metrics are at or below the following floors for 2 sustained weeks, managers should form a group to analyze the cause and suggest actions to correct the trend.

1. Combined First Reply Time (L&R, GitLab SM and GitLab SaaS) at or below 93%
1. Combined SSAT (L&R, GitLab SM and GitLab SaaS) at or below 93%
1. Combined NRT (L&R, GitLab SM and GitLab SaaS) at or below 83%

This action is unique to Support and is somewhere in-between a Rapid Action issue and a Working Group.

The purpose of the group will be unique to each situation that triggers it, but generally the members will:

- form testable statements (e.g. FRT has gone down because a lot of people have taken vacation)
- gather and analyze data that falsify those statements (e.g. After taking a look at PTO data, we can see that we've had a consistent 90% coverage for the period in question, which is consistent with other times in the year)
- build a set of recommendations based on the data for how we can achieve consistent results
- document how they analyzed their hypothesis and include it in Hypothesis and Actions

These criteria and actions came from the Metrics Analysis Workgroup.

Forming a Group

1. A manager opens an issue using the Metrics Workgroup Template
1. Identify 2-3 Managers/ICs who will take part in the workgroup by asking for volunteers in a leadership meeting.
1. Determine hypothesis, gather data and propose temporary or permanent process changes as a result.

OKR's

All Support Engineering Managers have at least 1 OKR each quarter. Each managers' OKR should align with one of the department level OKR's, although the scope may be smaller (confined to a region/team of direct reports rather than globally impactful). While OKR's are important, they are not the most important thing for managers to work on. To the end of effectively managing Support Engineers, a managers focus should be on:

1. KPIs
1. Team Growth (Hiring and Development)
1. OKRs

Having a project that is time bound to a quarter is completely acceptable as an OKR, and adjusting an OKR during the quarter (especially in light of other priorities) is also acceptable.

New managers will establish their own OKR after they have been in their role for a full financial quarter, allowing time for them to complete onboarding and see the OKR process in action.

Support Engineering Manager READMEs

Support Engineering Manager READMEs are found in Engineering Manager READMEs.

SECTION: support/managers/amer.md

How to prioritize

One of the challenges in a growing and transparent organization is "how to prioritize". We can use the following guidance as a reference. Note: If you need to re-prioritize, communicate what you are going to drop, and what you need help with. Prioritization does not mean "do more" it means "do the right things in the right order":

1. Unassigned Account Escalations -- These will always be top priority. Consider shifting anything to take DRI of a Customer Escalation.
1. Customer Emergencies (or .Com Incidents)
1. Requests for assistance with STAR'd tickets - An On-call manager may ask for assistance with a STAR'd ticket. We should re-prioritize to help get attention on these issues.
1. Regularly scheduled work or work in progress.

SECTION: support/managers/areas-of-focus.md

Attributes

Property	Value
Date Created	2020-11-02
Date Ended	2021-04-22
Slack	sptareas-of-focus (only accessible from within the company)
Google Doc	Areas of Focus Workgroup Agenda (only accessible from within the company)
Playlist of Meetings	Areas of Focus Workgroup Playlist

KPIs that triggered this action

Service Level Agreement (SLA)

Exit Criteria

- SaaS and SM has been coalesced in Zendesk
- Tom A's "Areas of Focus" initiative has been implemented

Roles and Responsibilities

Working Group	Role	Person	Title	Region
--	--	--	--	--
Facilitator	Jason Colyer	Support Operations Manager	AMER	
Executive Stakeholder	Tom Cooney	VP of Support	AMER	
Member	Tom Atkins	Support Engineering Manager (EMEA)	EMEA	
Member	Jane Gianoutsos	Support Engineering Manager (APAC)	APAC	
Member	Ronnie Alfaro	Support Engineering Manager (AMER)	AMER	
Member	Cynthia Ng	Senior Support Engineer (AMER)	AMER	

Artifacts

SECTION: support/managers/change-management.md

Decision Making and Change Management in the GitLab Support Leadership Team

The GitLab Support Team may very well be unique among the many teams within the company in that its multiple sub-teams each have the same charter. Making decisions and managing change within this structure come with equally unique challenges not faced by the other teams. Specifically, managers must determine the appropriate scope - whether to act individually or in coordination with the other managers - when they want to make a decision or introduce a process change. And the worldwide support management team must agree that the scoping is correct. We define here our most current processes for determining scope, gathering data and feedback, choosing a path forward, rolling out a change, managing adoption, and reviewing results for future improvements.

We'll talk about two different types of changes:

1. Process changes
1. Individual assignment and responsibilities changes

Process changes

This process is not limited to the GitLab Support Leadership Team

If you're looking to roll out a global change (see definition below), you might have been directed to this process. Global changes are commonly but not exclusively handled by the GitLab Support Leadership Team. For that reason, this process is documented within the "Managers" handbook section.

This does not mean the process should only be followed by managers. If you're having trouble with any part of it, reach out for guidance - either to your manager or to SEs who followed the process before.

Examples of SEs using the process:

- Slack groups per region
- Limit PagerDuty Notifications in supportself-managed to Triggered Events

Start with a Request for Comments (RFC)

An RFC is a safe space for a lively discussion where all contributors bring their own context and knowledge to determine the pros and cons of potential solutions.

In an RFC everyone contributes equally, regardless of their title.

If you have an idea (or have noticed a problem) but aren't ready to propose specific changes yet, you can start with the Request for Comments issue template. The template includes guidance on how to make your RFC.

Determining the Scope

One of the most important considerations when looking to make a change is what the scope of the change will be.

Local Change or Global Change?

When thinking about whether a change should be local or global, you might be tempted to focus on the size of the change (number of lines of code changed, number of lines of text in a doc that changed, etc.). But that's actually a different type of scope that isn't relevant to this discussion.

Instead, begin with the idea that for the sake of consistency and simplicity, you should lean toward making your change globally unless it doesn't even make sense for, or apply to, other regions. If you're considering making the change locally, be sure that you can answer "no" to all of these questions about potential impacts of making a local change:

1. Will it create a meaningful inconsistency with the rest of the global team?

Examples:

1. Your local work products become incompatible with those of the other teams

1. Terminologies or workflows diverge between your local team and the others, inhibiting collaboration

1. Other teams can't work in concert with yours because they don't have access to new tools and resources yours is using

1. Will customers notice the local change?

If so:

1. Will customers be inconvenienced or even just annoyed by having to work differently in some way with your team than with the other teams?

1. Will customers' expectations of "normal" service continue to be met?

1. Will customers like your change enough to be dissatisfied when other teams or regions don't do the same thing?

1. Will it create different job descriptions or performance measures between your team and the other regions?

Communicating a Change Proposal

Whether you're making a local change, based on the decision criteria above, or proposing a global one, it's important to communicate your plans with the rest of the Support Leadership Team.

Creating a Requested Change Issue and/or MRs

The first step toward making a change is to create a Requested Change issue in the support-team-meta project.

Using the linked template (Requested Change), it will ensure you supply the required information (DRI, problem statement, ways to measure success, etc.), helping to speed the process along.

This issue is used for presenting the problem that you are working to solve, for hosting a discussion around that topic, and for documenting the testing phase.

As soon as possible, create the documentation MR(s) and/or companion issues for Customer Support Operations to present the actual proposed changes.

Include at least the following in the MRs:

- The decision and the reasoning behind it (such as data and test results that led to the decision)
- Summarize the testing, both what tests were run and what the results were
- Link to the Message Plan Issue
- Add the label ~"Manager Attention" to ensure that the support management team are informed about the proposed change
- As an additional guardrail also add the group @gitlab-com/support/managers to the issue to ensure that the support management team are informed about the proposed change

We use the rollout issue template to get acknowledgement of awareness of a new workflow or process.

NOTE: If there's any part of the proposed changes that cannot be presented through a MR, place the information in the issue instead.

Communicating a Local Change Proposal

Inform the leadership team as an "inform" item in the agenda for the next leadership sync meeting.

Why?

- Someone else might have a suggestion for you
- Someone else might be interested in what you're doing
- It aligns well with our Transparency value

Communicating a Global Change Proposal

Engage the leadership team in a conversation through your issue and through a full agenda topic in the leadership sync meeting:

- Describe the problem you're working to solve
- Let the team know if you are the DRI, or are seeking a DRI
- Let the team know whether you're proposing a solution based on compelling existing data or you're planning to conduct one or more tests (trials) to determine which solution to propose.
- Add the label ~"Manager Attention" to ensure that the support management team are informed about the proposed change
- As an additional guardrail also add the group @gitlab-com/support/managers to ensure that the support management team are informed about the proposed change
 - If you will be testing, then it's suggested that you:
 - Present potential solutions and discuss which of them will be tried
 - Discuss any likely impacts of the tests
 - Gain general agreement that you can proceed with your tests
 - If the tests will be large and long running, consider opening an issue for each test and link them all to your issue
 - Otherwise, it's suggested that you:
 - present data both demonstrating the need for the change and supporting the solution you've chosen
 - propose your solution via a Merge Request (linked to your issue) and invite feedback with a reasonable deadline
- Describe how you plan to measure the success of the change (not just the tests)

Constructing a Valuable Test Plan

We make data driven decisions whenever possible. If your proposed change doesn't have any supporting data, you'll run one or more localized trials. Be frugal if there is a cost and always be sensitive to disrupting existing workflows:

- If you are not confident or comfortable designing a test, work with other managers to flesh out ideas.
- Keep in mind that there's a difference between the scope (local or global) of a change and the scope of a test. A global change most likely will not require a global test.
- Run the tests just long enough to get the data you need
- Involve only as many people, teams and regions as you need to make the tests legitimate
- If a test in the production environment would be problematic, look for a way to run it in a sandbox instead
- If running more than one trial:
 - try to run them in parallel with each other to save time
 - limit your testing to the two or three most likely potential solutions

Standard Timelines

For future iterations:

1. Do we want to have standard timelines for certain steps in a rollout?

- Initial discussion length
- Days from rollout start to adoption complete

1. Do we want to weigh the impact of changes to ensure that we aren't changing too many complex things at once?

Rolling Out a Change

Roles in Change Management

During the rollout, use these terms and their provided descriptions to communicate clearly about the different roles people can play in the change process.

| Role | Description |

| --- | --- |

| Champion | Person who will advocate for the change due to their strong interest in, and possible responsibility for, the success of the change. Most of the time champions are managers. |

| User | Person who uses the processes, documents and resources that are being changed. |

| Impacted Non-User | Person who is not an actual user of the processes, documents and resources that are being changed, yet who will experience changes in the behaviors of the users.
E.g. Support Engineers may notice managers responding differently to escalations, though they themselves do not need to do anything new. |

The Process Change Rollout Plan

When it's time at last to make the change, create a Process Change Rollout Plan issue.

The process change rollout plan template contains instructions to guide you through filling in all the appropriate details. And the issue itself then describes your full action plan.

Individual assignment and responsibilities changes

These types of changes are almost always local and small. An example:

- Changing the workload balance of an SE to have them spend more time sharing knowledge and less time taking tickets

The motivation for these changes could come from a need to manage individual performance and development, balance resources, improve expertise distribution, or address other similar items.

Although planning of such a change tends to occur outside of issues (for confidentiality reasons), and to be conducted between managers and directors,

if it will impact people other than those directly involved, consider taking one or more of the following actions before making the change:

1. Explain your plan and ask for concerns and questions in your region's next managers' sync.
1. Host two separate cross-regional meetings, one with each of the regions other than your own, to explain your plan and ask for concerns and questions.

SECTION: support/managers/getting-to-know-you.md

Introduction

One of our most important functions as managers in GitLab's Support Team is to provide a safe, inclusive, supportive environment in which our team members (direct reports) will be happy, productive and successful. We want them to feel valued. We want to reward them for outstanding contributions. We want to give them opportunities to grow and to be challenged. We want to offer guidance for improvement when it's needed and get out of the way when it's not. We want to be a readily available, trusted resource rather than a crutch or a burden.

Given the uniqueness of each person on each of our teams, though, and their correspondingly varied needs, skills, personalities and behaviors, how can we possibly hope to succeed in this endeavor? We will need to tailor our management approach uniquely for each individual team member. Offered on this page is what we believe to be a good first step in doing that, and in becoming not just a good manager, but the right manager for each individual member of your team.

Laying the Foundation for a Tailored Management Approach

Begin each manager/direct-report relationship, whether you are the new manager on the team or you have a new member joining the team that you manage, with a special one-on-one meeting. The agenda for the meeting is two-part, and essentially amounts to this:

1. Tell your story to your team member
1. Ask the team member to tell their story to you

It's important that you each give enough information about your personal and professional background so that the other person can begin to know who you are, what's important to you, what's meaningful to you, and how you do work. And as you'll see when you look at the template for this meeting, you as the manager have the added responsibility of learning specific details about how to work with your team member.

Preparing for and Conducting the Meeting

1. Use the All About You Template
 1. Copy it to a folder in Google Drive where both of you will have access
 1. Add the team member's name to the file name (e.g. All About Lee Matos)
 1. Fill in their name inside the file, too, replacing <Team member>
1. In the calendar invitation, include a link to the new file. Invite the team member to fill it out in advance OR to wait for the meeting at which time you will take notes in the doc while they tell their story.
1. Use your Support Engineering Manager Readme
 1. If your Readme covers your whole story, meaning it answers pretty much all the questions in the template, then ask your team member to read it in advance.
 1. Here's an example of one such complete Readme
1. Conduct the Meeting!
 1. Build trust by being vulnerable - tell your story first. If your Readme tells the whole story, you can just ask your team member for any comments or questions they have. Otherwise, start by using the template as a guide and filling in the gaps between it and your Readme. Then ask for comments and questions.
 1. Then seek to learn about them
 1. Remind them of what the document calls out at the top - that they should only share what they feel comfortable sharing, and that the only purpose is for the two of you to learn about each other and how best to work together.
 1. Go through every question in the document, either reviewing the answers they've already provided or taking notes as they answer at that time. Remember that, unlike in a job interview, you can talk about almost whatever you want. Learn about them. Share stories as you find common interests and experiences. Build a connection.
 1. Thank them for going through this process with you.

Then What?

Now that you have all this terrific information about your team member, make use of it all the time! In the beginning, you might consider looking through it before each one-on-one to refresh your memory on, well, everything. Over time you'll probably remember some of the information and not need it as a cheat sheet. Still, continue to use it as a reference as necessary. Some good uses are:

- When you want to recognize them for an achievement, look to the document to remind yourself of how they want to be recognized
- When you want to talk about their development plan, look to the document to remind yourself what they've already told you about their aspirations
- When you want to coach them about something, look back to see how they want to work with their manager and receive feedback

All About You

For those who don't have access to the Google Doc, the text of the template follows.

What's this all about?

The purpose of this document is to facilitate a conversation between your manager and you about who you are, what you want, and how the two of you can best work together. It should be kept handy so that your manager can refer to it whenever they need to be sure they're following your guidance on being a great manager for you.

Personal Background & Interests

Tell me anything you want me to know about who you are, and NOTHING you think is none of my business. I just want to learn about you so that I will learn about how to be a good manager for you.

Childhood

- Where did you grow up?
- Please tell me about growing up with your siblings, parents, and others

Education

- Where did you go?
- What did you study?

Current Situation

- Where (actual location) are you now and how did you get there?
- Do you have family of your own? Tell me about them.

Fun

- Hobbies? Interests? Activities? Passions?

Professional Background & Interests

- What did you do before GitLab?
- What brought you here?
- What is your dream career?
- What do you love to do at work?
- What do you "prefer not to do?"

Management Tips

- What do you want most from me as your manager?
- What should I avoid as your manager?
- What motivates you at work? What demotivates you?
- What excites you at work?
- What expectations do you have of yourself?
- How do you like to be rewarded and recognized?

- Reward - what types of rewards really mean the most to you? Cash? Personalized gift? Special time off?
- Recognition - where do you fall on the spectrum between "love and need public recognition" and "only want private recognition?"
- What else do I need to know in order to be a really good manager for you?

SECTION: support/managers/hazards-and-challenges.md

Hazards & Challenges

Team morale suffers

Hazard	Commitment
Ticket volume is too high	Build (and adjust) hiring model based on the best data available, hire as quickly as possible while keeping quality up.
Team knowledge doesn't match ticket difficulty	Develop training materials, provide time for professional development, encourage specializations.
We aren't hitting our SLOs	Hire and train as per above. Add regularity to scheduling and encourage efficient work patterns.
Leadership breaks trust	Communicate in public channels, alert early and often of potential discussions, engender the GitLab value of Transparency.
Fear of conflict results in poor decisions	Provide focus on meta-issues by triaging issues in the Active Now board. Encourage buy-in and bravery. Truly listen and respond. Explicitly overrule: state reasoning and thank everyone for voicing opinions.
Team lacks commitment to results or implementing decisions	Ensure voices are heard. Reinforce "disagree and commit". Build accountability.
There's no accountability in poor results or not meeting commitments	Reinforce GitLab value of Results by paying attention and following up.
Lack of trust as the team grows	Make an intentional effort to frequently do pairing sessions between regions.

Scaling

As we continue to increase in size, there's a number of challenges that we need to address and/or questions we need to answer:

As we grow:

1. What process inefficiencies do we need to address? (e.g. Do all engineers need to know about every component/configuration/deployment strategy of GitLab, or are there ways we can specialize?)
1. Which process inefficiencies do we need to intentionally keep because of a positive externality? (e.g. Do we keep around a synchronous meeting because it helps build relationships?)
1. What have we lost in scaling? How can we build it back in a way that scales? (e.g. Smaller groups lead to more ideation sessions, how can we make sure we're creating spaces for ideas to build off of each other?)

1. How can we make sure we're broadcasting things appropriately so no one misses out on an important piece of information?

SECTION: support/managers/hiring.md

Hiring new Customer Support team members is a multi-department process involving talent acquisition and customer support.

Support Engineers comprise the vast majority of Customer Support. This page presents information specific to that job family. Exceptions are called out explicitly, such as in the Reviewing Assessments section.

Hiring flow

Hiring is described on the jobs page for Support Engineers. The following are the stages carried out by Customer Support team members.

Sourcing

If you have open positions on your team, you should join (or arrange) a source-a-thon on a regular basis to proactively identify candidates our recruiters can reach out to. More information can be found on the general Sourcing page.

Technical questionnaire

GitLab Participant: Support Engineer

The assessment questionnaire contains a number of customer scenarios and technical questions relevant to the position, including written English ability. Support engineers are responsible for reviewing the candidate responses.

Technical interview

GitLab Participant: Support Engineer

The technical interview for this role is conducted by support engineers. It is a practical interview that covers topical areas relevant to the position, including customer scenarios.

Behavioural panel interview

GitLab Participants: Support Manager and one other (Support Manager or Support Engineer). At least one interviewer will be non-male.

The behavioural interview may cover any topics of the previous interviews where there was unclear data or a need to dive deeper.

Final interview

GitLab Participants: Senior Support Manager or Director, Customer Support

Candidates successful in all previous interviews may proceed to a Senior Manager or Director, Customer Support interview.

Scorecard Feedback

GitLab Participants: Support Manager, Senior Support Manager

Managers are invited to provide feedback on scorecards submitted by other interviewers, in order to help improve the interviewing process. This feedback should be provided directly to the individual interviewer.

Getting involved

If you want to be involved in the hiring process - let your manager know! The main ways you can be involved are:

- reviewing technical assessments
- conducting technical interviews

Each of these have a training module. The technical assessments don't involve direct interaction with candidates, however the technical interviews do, so a component of the training module is to complete the GitLab Interview training. Have a chat with your manager, then create and complete your training issue.

- Stage 1 - Assessment Review Training
- Stage 2 - Technical Interview Training

Reviewing Assessments

Guidelines for reviewing and giving feedback on assessments for the Support Engineer role can be found in the Support-Assessment-Solutions project.

Assessments are assigned by the support aligned Recruiter in the Talent Acquisition team. These are carried out asynchronously, so you could be asked to review assessments from candidates in all regions.

Assessments that are sent to candidates for all Support job families are available in the people-ops/hiring-processes repository.

Technical Interviews

The technical interview process is documented in the Support Team project. Follow the instructions there to conduct this interview. Take any notes in Greenhouse and make a note if you are inclined or not inclined to hire. Your role in the interview process for this candidate is complete!

Pre-Hiring

Before you can do any of the above you'll need to have an open requisition and a vacancy in that requisition. You can learn more about these terms and the process at Requisitions and Vacancies in the Hiring Section of the Handbook.

How a candidate gets routed to a manager

Hiring Plan

The VP of Customer Support is the DRI for the hiring plan. They will ensure that headcount is allocated to regions and approximate hiring dates.

Vacancies

1. When headcount is allocated, the Support Hiring Report - Hiring Plan(internal only) will be updated by the hiring team.

For each vacancy there should be a:

- Job title
- Region
- Hiring Manager
- Opening ID
- Opening Status
- Target/Actual Start Date
- Candidate

1. When we get close to the target start date, the talent acquisition team will update Greenhouse with the vacancy and assign it an Opening ID.

1. When a vacancy is open in Greenhouse, the hiring manager (or Sr. Manager) will be noted in the spreadsheet.

Source-a-thons

A source-a-thon is a synchronous or asynchronous activity where one or more individuals gets together to actively look for candidates.

If you want to participate, make sure you upgrade your LinkedIn Account.

More general information about this activity is on the general Source-a-thon page.

AMER - Sip 'n Source

On the first Monday of each month we have a Source-a-thon called the "Sip 'n Source". The position we'll be sourcing for will change depending on need, but bring a special drink, get ready for some music and get ready to source! If you can't join, that's okay, you can still participate async.

Specific outcomes:

- Each manager sources ≥ 40 candidates per month (10 per week)

Each month, before the synchronous event:

- AMER Managers identify REQs that need specific sourcing
- An AMER Senior Manager creates a new source-a-thon issue laying out the specific role, focuses and goals.
- AMER Senior Manager tags each AMER manager with a checkbox for completion
- AMER Senior Manager sets a due date for the end of the month

SECTION: support/managers/leadership-sync.md

Purpose

Support leadership (Managers, Senior Managers and Director) participate in cross-regional meetings weekly.

The purpose of these meetings is to:

- build relationships, trust and context between managers
- address operational items such as availability
- explain context for issues and explore creative ideas in real time
- refine the problem statement of each raised issue by clarifying intent

The purpose of these meetings is not to:

- figure out the priority of issues
- gather feedback that can be given asynchronously on related issues
- refine solutions or merge requests related to issues
- make decisions

Note: It is worth reiterating that these meetings are not for making decisions or discussing things that could just as effectively be discussed within issues.

Organization of Support Leadership Meetings

Schedule

1. As a global team, we have to strike the right balance in using our synchronous time wisely, and be mindful of the time zones and people's availability. To enable this, the weekly leadership syncs rotate through one region every week.

1. The meetings are available in the GitLab Support calendar.

1. Every meeting is set to automatically record and the recording can be accessed via the GitLab Videos Recorded shared drive.

Agenda

1. The agenda and notes are in a Google Doc: Support leadership calls agenda and notes%22) (internal only)

1. The agenda outline for next week should be created as the last item in the current week's

sync. All agenda items should be added before the sync meeting of the week. Anything that is added later will most likely be ignored by most or all of the leadership, or not discussed, losing value. Appropriate Slack channels must be used to discuss any emergency items, especially if the sync meeting of the week is already done.

1. Please follow the below guidelines when adding agenda items:

1. Operational: This section is for standing weekly updates regarding Hiring, Availability, Customer Accounts, Team Call-Outs etc.

1. Discuss: Items under this section should be for things that need to be synchronously discussed, or need input. These may or may not have an associated issue.

1. Inform: Items under this section are:

1. issues we want to bring to everybody's attention in order to request asynchronous input

1. things we should all be aware of, such as a new process around expense approval, updates from People Business Partner, etc.

1. Confidential Doc: Use this document for discussion surrounding a specific individual's promotion, performance or individual situation, discussion about sensitive or confidential issues and processes. Add See confidential doc item as an item under Inform or Discuss in the general agenda depending on the action required for the item you've added in the confidential doc.

1. Each meeting has a chairperson to ensure that voices are heard equally and we make progress through the agenda.

1. All participants should be familiar with the Video Calls Section of the Communication page in the Handbook.

1. See this video, Managing Support Leadership Sync Agendas and Meetings, for more information, including how to edit and use the agenda and notes document.

Call Procedure

As a chair

1. Review the meeting agenda before the meeting time.

1. Review the Operational section of the agenda and mention anything that may have an action item, or may need an action item such as:

1. Hiring data: Is there anything that is of note for the regions that are meeting?

1. Holidays: Do we have (or need) a coverage plan for this holiday?

1. Availability: How are the different regions looking in terms of availability next week?

1. Metrics Review: Is there anything that needs to be highlighted to the executive team?

1. Group Conversation: Please take a look at the slides, and add any points of interest for the general company

1. Facilitate discussion of the items in the Discuss section of the agenda document.

1. Be aware when people unmute - this is an indication that they have something to say. If necessary, please interrupt and pass the floor. We want everyone to contribute, so it's your job to make sure that this can happen.

1. Assign any action items - including summarizing the discussion in an issue.

1. Stop the recording before discussing items in the confidential doc, if there are any.

1. Create the agenda outline for next week from the template as the last step.

As a manager

1. Add agenda items no later than before the start of that week's sync meeting.
1. Review each agenda item. If you have any feedback for items under Discuss and will not be joining the meeting synchronously, add them under Async Notes for that item.

As a synchronous meeting participant

1. If you raised an item for discussion, be brief (everyone should be familiar with the discussion), clear (why did you bring this item to this meeting), and understanding (others may interrupt you while speaking due to the nature of video calls (For more on this see point 13 in the Video Calls Section of the Communication page)).
1. Use majority of the meeting time to build rapport with the folks on the call.
 1. Talk through team related call-outs, share tips and tricks, latest learnings and others.
 1. You should feel empowered to talk about things not on the agenda - sometimes, we need our peers' guidance and experience on things that might be bothering or challenging us.
1. After the meeting, note any points that you made during the meeting that were relevant to the discussion.

As an asynchronous meeting participant

1. Set aside time at the end of the week to review the agenda document and/or meeting recording from that week.
1. Make note of the things under Inform and Discuss, and contribute via respective issues.

Setting up the meetings

Due to some weirdness between the Zoom app and web UI, you have to do this in two parts:

Part 1 - Zoom app

Because the web UI does not allow for adding it to Google calendar, you need to start via the app.

In your Zoom app, click the Schedule button. This will bring up a window to add a scheduled meeting.

On this window:

1. Put the name of the meeting in the Topic box
1. Check the box for Recurring meeting
1. Under the Meeting ID section, check the bubble to Generate Automatically
1. Under the Security section, make sure to use the Passcode option
1. Under the Video section, have both On bubbles selected
1. Under the Audio section, have the Telephone and Computer Audio bubble selected
1. Under the Calendar section, have the Google Calendar bubble selected
1. Click the down arrow by Advanced Options and
 1. check the box for Allow participants to join anytime
 1. check the box for Automatically record meeting
 1. select the bubble for In the cloud

With all that done, click Save. This will then open a browser window to authenticate via Google

to add the event to the calendar.

When adding the event to the calendar, ensure:

1. The date, start time, end time, and timezone are correct (see Time Settings down below)
1. The recurring settings are correct (see Time Settings down below). This is found to the right of the All day box
1. You attach the Support Leadership Google doc
1. You put it on the GitLab Support calendar (option is right below the Add notification option)
1. You set the availability to Free (option is right below which calendar to put it on). This is vital to ensure it does not block customer calls.
1. Invite the correct list of people
 - <support-managers@gitlab.com>
1. Under Guest permissions, have the following boxes checked:
 - Invite others
 - See guest list

With that, click the Save button at the top-right.

Part 2 - Zoom web UI

Next we add the co-hosts for the meeting. To do this, go to My Meetings in the Zoom Web UI. Then locate the meeting in question , hover over it, and click the Edit button.

On the edit page, click the Options item (towards the bottom of the section) and then click in the box under Alternative Hosts.

You will now need to manually add each manager to the Alternative Hosts box. For a complete list, see the support-managers Google group member list.

Once you have added all of them in, click the blue Save button.

Time Settings for the meetings

Meeting	Start Time	End Time	Timezone	Recurring Schedule
[REC] Support Leadership Sync - APAC<>EMEA	0900	0950	+00:00 UTC	Every 3 weeks on Wednesday
[REC] Support Leadership Sync - AMER<>APAC-E	2200	2250	+00:00 UTC	Every 3 weeks on Wednesday
[REC] Support Leadership Sync - EMEA<>AMER	1600	1650	+00:00 UTC	Every 3 weeks on Thursday

SECTION: support/managers/manager-responsibilities.md

Introduction

1. This page is an extension of the Support Engineering manager job family page.
1. The aim of this page is to help you know how to carry out your responsibilities as a Support Engineering Manager.

Support Leadership at GitLab

Leadership at GitLab is a unique opportunity to embody and model the GitLab Values. The responsibilities of Support Managers can be grouped into two broad categories:

Responsibilities	GitLab Values
Consistently ensure high Customer Support Satisfaction	Results, Efficiency, Iteration, Transparency
Support and nurture team members in Customer Support	Collaboration, Diversity Inclusion Belonging

Our Hazards and Challenges page describes some known issues and how we handle them.

Consistently ensure high Customer Support Satisfaction

Our primary responsibility in the Support Leadership team is to ensure high quality Customer Support for GitLab customers. To fulfill this responsibility we set and achieve goals (aligned with GitLab Strategy and Engineering OKRs), and ensure Support Engineers can achieve their goals.

SSAT Responsibility	Sub-responsibility
Help support engineers to resolve tickets accurately and efficiently	Understand GitLab Support Service Levels and KPIs
	Know how we use Zendesk, Slack, and GitLab for ticket management
	Serve as Support Manager On-Call for Customer Emergencies and Escalations
	Monitor and respond to feedback your Support Engineers receive
	Know how to use Zendesk Explore to monitor KPIs
	Work with GitLab Sales, Pricing, Product, and other teams when company initiatives change Support requirements
Help Support Engineers to manage tickets, manage customer expectations, and communicate well	
Coach SEs on communication techniques	
	Understand Support Workflows and escalation paths
	Support your team members' participation in on-call rotations to coordinate and resolve emergencies
	Join Customer Calls with SEs on request or according to your judgement
	Propose, develop, and evaluate improvements to Support processes by acting as DRI for issues in the Support Meta project
Stay up-to-date on GitLab Product, Strategy, Pricing, etc.	Contribute to and read the Support Week in Review document every week
	Participate (at the Section level or cross-functional level) in Support Stable Counterparts or Cross-functional non-product counterparts

Support and nurture team members in Customer Support

We are equally responsible to ensure our team members are supported in their GitLab journey, and are able to bring their best selves to work every day.

Team Member Responsibility	Sub-responsibility
Support and nurture team members	Foster cross-regional connections among Support Engineers and Support Managers
	Create an inclusive environment and foster DIB values within the team
	Participate in Support Weekly Meetings
	Build strong working relationships with your colleagues in Support leadership through informal communication
	Conduct weekly 1:1s with each direct report
	Recommend projects, training, and leadership roles for your direct reports
	Support your direct reports who are Support Stable Counterparts or Cross-functional non-product counterparts
	Ensure regular professional/career development for each direct report
	Perform annual 360 Reviews and Performance Factor Reviews (compensation)
	Conduct Performance Factor reviews and Compensation reviews
	Handle any HR / People Group questions and topics from direct reports
	Review, approve, and merge GitLab Issues and MRs from direct reports
	Support your team members' participation in on-call rotations
	Develop your own skills through learning and training
	Develop your skills through direct interactions with customers and Support Engineers
Interview and hire new team members	Complete Interview Training learning module
	Maintain a flexible schedule for interview timeslots
	Stay up-to-date with the current Hiring Process
	Stay up-to-date with hiring plans in the weekly Manager Sync documents/meetings
	Grade assessments for SE and Manager candidates in Greenhouse
	Work with your regional Recruiter to source potential candidates
	Train Support Engineers via the Interview Training module to prepare them for grading technical assessments and performing technical interviews
Foster sense of community within and between regions	Coach and encourage team members to resolve challenges
	Engage in team building activities
	Interact with team members to amplify successes and understand regional and global challenges
	Encourage and support cross-region collaboration

Working in Slack

Ask and answer questions in Slack. (We don't have a way to easily track this, but feel free to share things you're proud of in 1:1 notes documents.)

Important Slack channels:

- 1. supportleadership
- 1. supportticket-attention-requests
- 1. sphiring
- 1. supportteamchat
- 1. thanks

- 1. team-member-updates
- 1. managers
- 1. eng-managers

Conducting weekly 1:1 meetings {conducting-weekly-1-1-meetings}

Weekly 1:1 meetings are a crucial part of Remote Culture at GitLab. Refer to the Support Engineer Responsibilities page to understand what your team members are aiming to achieve.

- 1. Review at least two tickets per team-member in 1:1 calls. This helps maintain and improve quality (technical, communication and collaboration).
- 1. Monitor for team members to have around 50% to 60% of public replies to be on tickets that are assigned to them. Assigning tickets helps resolve customer problems quickly and efficiently as well as encouraging learning and collaboration.
- 1. Help ensure your team members meet the ticket baseline for solved tickets, public replies, and internal notes for the type of tickets they are working on. This encourages the even distribution of ticket volume across the team.
- 1. Review notable Incidents/Emergencies and Customer Calls in 1:1 notes/meetings with your team members.
- 1. Discuss career development plans with team members at least once per quarter.

Develop your skills through learning and training

We are committed to helping you develop your skills through continuous learning. The GitLab Learning and Development team provides opportunities for exploration and training.

Be sure to include non-technical topics such as:

- 1. Psychological safety in teams
- 1. Time management
- 1. Leadership skills
- 1. Coaching skills
- 1. Diversity, inclusion, and belonging
- 1. Remote work
- 1. Trends and insights in the larger support world

Consider participating in Team Member Resource Groups, and ensure your team members know about these.

Consider participating in, creating, or publicizing a GitLab Book Club.

Support Engineers and Managers are also encouraged to complete courses and certification from external providers. Speak with your manager to plan your learning goals.

Develop your skills through direct interactions with customers and Support Engineers

We are committed to being managers who know and understand what Support Engineers do day to day..

The best way to be familiar with Support Engineer workflows and responsibilities is to step

into the shoes of the engineers.

Each week, Support Managers should do one or more of these activities:

- own and resolve one ticket from first reply to closing statement
- join a pairing session with one or more Support Engineers
- join a scheduled or emergency call

By continually engaging with workflows, tickets, and customers we can build empathy and understand pain points through first-hand experience.

In this way, we build trust with engineers and customers while creating a sense of psychological safety by demonstrating that it's okay not to know.

SECTION: support/managers/performance-management.md

What is this page?

This page is intended as a supporting structure for Support Managers in handling the particularities of performance in Support. It is not intended to replace the more comprehensive Underperformance Page in the Leadership section of the Handbook.

Goal setting

Managers should work with their reports to understand their current ability and their desire for growth. Using this understanding managers should set performance goals and track progress towards them on a regular cadence. (See Tracking your Career Development for some ways of doing this.) Performance goals should contribute towards achieving our global KPIs.

PTO, training and other context are important in goal setting and should be taken into account. In some cases, it might be prudent to set goals of minimal to zero contributions towards team goals to help encourage engineers to focus on these individual activities. Below are some common areas for goal setting:

FRT and Ticket Assignment

Contributing to the achievement of our first reply time target and taking assignment of tickets are Support Engineer Core Responsibilities.

Public and internal comments

To maintain good progress through to resolution on all assigned tickets and help others maintain progress on their tickets engineers must communicate with our customers and collaborate with their peers. Public and internal comments can be an indication of performance, but be careful not to confuse it with the desired result of solved tickets.

See: Ticket Baselines

Docs/Product MRs

Docs and Product MRs help prevent future tickets. All Engineers should be submitting Docs MRs regularly.

See:

- Performance Indicators - Support MR Rate
- Improve documentation and publicly share knowledge
- Fix GitLab bugs and create features

Pairing Sessions

Pairing sessions are good to be aware of, especially if skills-based performance is being coached.

See: Collaborate with team members

Training

Support Engineers should regularly be working to expand their skills base through whatever resources are appropriate, be it Support Training Modules, LinkedIn Learning courses, pairing sessions, or other activities organized by GitLab Learning and Development.

See: Develop your skills through learning and training

Detecting underperformance

Individual performance can be challenging to measure: week over week performance may be clouded by PTO, or time spent focusing on areas that have a high number of hours invested for a low overall output. For example, a Support Engineer working with a customer in an escalated state may spend many hours working on a challenging problem, take no new tickets during that time, and produce a small number of comments that solve the case. But when considered over time, such indicators can be helpful at evaluating results.

For a more complete look, see warning signs / patterns of underperformance.

Underperformance in Support

Underperformance for Support Engineers is defined as an Engineer not meeting their agreed upon goals for 4 consecutive weeks.

Working through Underperformance

Managers should act early by having a conversation with their direct report when a team member is underperforming. A good guideline to what is "early" is when a support engineer hasn't been meeting their goals for four consecutive weeks. At this point you should discuss the situation

and plan for moving forward with your manager.

Once you and your manager agree, the next steps are to:

- loop in the Team Member Relations Partner
- Have a conversation with your direct report:
 - review GitLab's guidelines on providing feedback, and any additional training you have received
 - communicate that you have identified specific behaviors that indicate the team member is not currently performing to standards (include specific examples)
 - be clear that this discussion is not a formal verbal warning or written warning
 - ensure psychological safety and provide space for the team member to respond and raise concerns
 - identify and form an action plan

If the goals in an action plan are not met over the next two weeks after this conversation, go to your manager and begin working on options for remediation with Team Member Relations.

SECTION: support/managers/promoting-a-support-team-member.md

Support Engineer Promotion Process for Support Managers - Quick Guide

The company-wide People Group process should be followed For Managers: Requesting a Promotion or Compensation Change. The steps below are an addendum for notification and review for Support Engineering managers, taking into account the Customer Support Department's organisational structure, and is not meant as a replacement for any steps in the company-wide people group process.

Planning

We follow the promotion cadence published by the People Group.
Regularly:

1. Update the then-current Support Promotion Projections spreadsheet to be sure each of your candidates is listed and has an appropriate projected promotion target.
1. Review each of your candidates' progress toward promotion.

If you have any questions, please ask your manager or our People Business Partner.

Calibration

In Support we start the promotion-docs review process as soon as the documents are ready for review.

- Create the promotion document using the appropriate template:
 - Promotion to Senior Support Engineer - Template
 - FY23Q3+ Promotion to Staff Support Engineer -- link TBD, updates in

this Epic

- Add a link to the document into the Support Promotions Projects spreadsheet
- Complete the document with the Support Engineer
- Create a public Google Docs view link to the document for everyone at GitLab to allow sharing, as this is the document that will be used in the promotion calibration and approval process
- Discuss the promotion candidate with your manager
- Gather feedback from the Support Managers by:
 - making a copy of the promotion document and setting permissions on it so that only the Support Managers can see it (ensure they can Edit)
 - inviting them in the confidential cross-regional sync doc to provide feedback by the date of your choosing
- Update the public document based on the feedback from the Support Managers
- Get the approval to proceed from your manager

Submission

- Follow the For Managers: Requesting a Promotion or Compensation Change process

Announcement

- Once approval has been received from People team, notify the support engineer.
- Ask the Support Engineer to create a checklist issue for themselves to update their job title where appropriate.
- Announce in the team-member-updates Slack channel.
- Share the message from team-member-updates into the support-team-chat channel for Support Team visibility.
- Go multi-modal and add an announcement to the Support Week in Review (SWIR), using the "Team Member Updates" category
- Move the promotion doc to the Individual Docs folder in the shared Support drive on Google Drive.

SECTION: support/managers/senior-leadership-sync.md

Purpose

Senior Support leadership (VP, Directors, and Senior Managers) participate in cross-regional meetings weekly.

The purpose of these meetings is to:

- build relationships, trust and context amongst senior leaders
- raise and identify DRIs for operational and strategic items
- explain context for issues and explore creative ideas in real time
- refine the problem statement of each raised issue by clarifying intent

The purpose of these meetings is not to:

- figure out the priority of issues
- gather feedback that can be given asynchronously on related issues
- refine solutions or merge requests related to issues
- make decisions

Note: It is worth reiterating that these meetings are not for making decisions or discussing things that could just as effectively be discussed within issues.

Organization of Senior Support Leadership Meetings

Schedule

1. As a smaller team of leaders, we have a single meeting slot that does not rotate.
1. The meetings are available in the GitLab Support calendar.
1. As we may flow in and out of confidential and non-confidential information, meetings are not recorded. However, the agenda is available to all GitLab Team Members and includes notes.

Agenda

1. The agenda and notes are in a Google Doc: Senior Support Manager Sync (internal only) - also attached to the meeting invite.
1. Please follow the below guidelines when adding agenda items:
 1. FYI: Prepend any agenda items with FYI that don't need discussion, but are important to know about
 1. Confidential Item: Please note in the agenda that you have a confidential item to discuss and put it in the confidential doc. Use this document for discussion surrounding a specific individual's promotion, performance or individual situation, discussion about sensitive or confidential issues and processes.
 1. All participants should be familiar with the Video Calls Section of the Communication page in the Handbook.

Standing Items

Weekly

- Metrics and KPIs

Monthly

- Upcoming promotions
- Underperformance
- Discretionary Bonuses

Quarterly

- Team building budget

SECTION: support/managers/support-1-1s.md

Aims and context

At GitLab we have weekly 1:1s.

The aim of this page is to:

1. Encourage consistency across the global Support team when discussing Support Engineer Responsibilities
1. Help make work visible

This page does not:

1. Prescribe exactly how a 1:1 should be conducted - these are guidelines
1. Include guidance on how to discuss career development, performance reviews and personal issues. Please leave time in 1:1s for these other important areas.

Guidelines:

1. You should be able to cover the key components outlined on this page in 10 to 15 minutes.
1. Leave time for general conversation and other important areas like career development.
1. Some weeks you may focus entirely on another area (e.g. personal issues, or a project you're working on)
1. Sometimes you may wish to schedule a longer or additional call to focus on an important area

1:1 Issue Generator Project

You may choose to use the 1:1 Issue Generator for your 1:1s. See the project Readme for more details.

Call structure

0. Pre-call

1. Select ticket(s) for review (see below)
1. Review activity links (see below)

1. Starting the call

Most people like to start the call with five minutes of general conversation.

We recommend avoiding small talk openers like 'How are you doing?'. Instead, set the context and get precise, actionable information. Some examples:

- Use a five point scale and ask 'On a scale of one to five, how are you feeling this week?' (see below for sample text).
- Ask for two ratings on a 0-10 scale, one for "stress" and one for "happiness."

Pay attention to trends over time.

Questions like these help open the conversation and put the work-related aspects in context.

(Credit for the idea from this GitLab conversation.)

Give the Support Engineer the opportunity to raise anything important they would like to discuss near the beginning of the call. You might want to skip the sections below if there are more important things to focus on.

2. How was ticket work this week?

The core focus of a Support Engineers' work is helping customers by resolving support tickets, so it's important to spend some time each week discussing this work.

A. Ticket Review

Each week you should review two tickets together during the 1:1 call. This can be done in 5 to 10 minutes. It's not an in-depth review. Details on how to do this are in the Working on Tickets page. We recommend that the manager reads some tickets before the call so that you are ready with concise feedback. The Comments Review tab on your personal Zendesk Explore dashboard is a good place to locate relevant tickets. The table on the left shows tickets that your reports have made more than one comment on in the last week. This makes it easy to find tickets they have been primarily focused on.

B. Public replies on assigned tickets (optional discussion)

Take a look at your team's Zendesk Explore dashboard and see how they're doing with the goal of around 50-60% of public replies on tickets that are assigned to themselves. Details about this on the Working on Tickets page.

It's likely you can skip this section if people are successfully balancing their contributions.

C. Meeting the ticket baseline (optional discussion)

Take a look at your team's Zendesk Explore dashboard and see if they are meeting the ticket baseline. Details about this on the Support Engineer responsibilities page.

It's likely you can skip this section if you're happy with the contributions people are making.

3. Discuss career development and learning

Discuss the career development and learning aspirations of the Support Engineer at least quarterly and provide guidance to help reach the goals.

Agree on and document a training plan that accommodates those aspirations and meets the needs of the support team in terms of enhancing team skills and filling knowledge gaps.

Agree on checkin points to review progress and, if necessary, to assist the Support Engineer in prioritizing and allocating the time required for Learning and Development.

Further details on Career Development Page

4. Discuss other activities from responsibility areas

Discuss interesting activities from the activity links at the top of the document (see below for examples).

There may be activities that the Support Engineer would like to discuss that aren't included in the activity links.

5. Time Off

- Ask whether the SE has had a day off in the past month, and if not encourage them to plan for one soon
- Ask whether they have upcoming time off, and if they do:
 - remind them to review the Support Team Member Time Off page and then to get appropriate coverage for their tickets and roles
 - ask them if they have any questions about what to do
 - set a reminder for the day before the first PTO date to check with the SE if they've not yet reported to you on their progress in getting coverage
- If they've had time off recently, ask whether they made all necessary coverage arrangements and discuss any problems that either of you observed

6. Other discussions

Everyone has different things they like to focus on in 1:1s. The rest of the call should focus on things the Support Engineer and manager would like to discuss.

Text and links for the 'header' of 1:1 notes documents

All 1:1 notes documents should include similar text and links at the top.

1. How are you feeling this week on a scale of 1 to 5?

- 1. Very positive
- 1. More positive than usual
- 1. Same as usual
- 1. Not as good as usual
- 1. Not great right now

2. Activity Links

- 1. Assigned tickets: <https://gitlab.zendesk.com/agent/users/{USERID}/assignedtickets> Replace {USERID} with the engineer's ZenDesk userid (shown in the address bar when viewing their profile).
- 1. All tickets commented on: <https://gitlab.zendesk.com/agent/search/1?q=commenter%3A{USERID}%20orderby%3Aupdatedat%20sort%3Adesc> Replace {USERID} with the engineer's ZenDesk userid
- 1. Pairings completed - Link to the pairings summary page
- 1. Bug report and feature requests - Link example
- 1. Documentation updates - Link example
- 1. Bug fixes - Link example
- 1. Learning and training progress - Link example

1. Customer calls? (Currently no link for this item. Included as a reminder to mention customer calls completed in the last week.)

1. Interviews? (Currently no link for this item. Included as a reminder to mention interviews completed in the last week.)

SECTION: support/managers/metrics-analysis/_index.md

2020-08

Attributes

Property Value

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